SCENE I

Chandauli, Uttar Pradesh

It was Holi that day. March 17, 2022. This corner of the Far East of UP too thrilled to the bee-swarm of colours that swept the rest of the Gangetic plains. In Chandauli, Ajay Kumar Gupta, 35, looked like the regular man on the block—the generic 'uncleji' to neighbourhood kids like Deepu and Pawan (*names changed*), both 15. Lured by good food and Holi *mithai*s, they entered his house. Spiked drinks followed, or perhaps beer. Once they were sufficiently off-kilter, Gupta ordered them to undress; then to touch and fondle each other...and, gradually, to scale it up to all sexual permutations possible. They were unaware all their actions were being recorded. After the videography was done, Gupta forced himself on the boys while they kept screaming in pain. They were too scared—this exploitation had been going on for three years, each time ending in dire threats and some trifling gifts. Later, Gupta sent the videos via WhatsApp and Telegram to his friend Ajit Kumar, an assistant loco pilot in Odisha's Rourkela, and also 35. Thus, he completed the circle, joining the primary economy of the paedophilic sexual hunt, like a black river, to the digital oceans out there.

SCENE II

Thanjavur, Tamil Nadu

This January, a message went out from Google to an email account far away from Chandauli. "It looks like this account has content that involves a child being sexually abused or exploited," it read. "This is a severe violation of Google's policies and might be illegal. If you think your account was disabled by mistake, submit an appeal as soon as possible." It was no mistake, of course. Except that J. Victor James Raja, a 35-year-old PhD scholar, usually preferred foraging for those of similar inclination on more penumbral zones of the internet, though not excluding niche social media apps like Grindr and Blued. This time, he had uploaded the video on a website run by an international gang. But it had also ended up on Google Cloud while he added it to his personal Gmail account—he had built up a little library that had been expanding for a few years. The video, which ended his run, left no room for ambiguity. It was a self-shot clip, and featured him sexually assaulting a 10-year-old girl.

These scenarios might, at first sight, seem like trailers of an OTT series devoted to fringe deviants and their twisted lives. But scenes like these are playing out all over India, with no particular bias with regard to geography or class—and rather too frequently for the phenomenon to remain unknown, unnamed and unremarked-upon. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) logged 149,404 cases of crime against children in 2021—16 per cent higher than in 2020. Of these, 53,874, or 36 per cent, were registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (PoCSO) Act, 2012. As many as 33,348 of those came under Sections 4 and 6 of the Act, relating to penetrative sexual assault and aggravated penetrative sexual assault. The real numbers, as often happens, would be much higher—for reasons of personal trauma, fear and social shame, an overwhelming majority of victim stories never reach the police.

Now, that zone of personal crime—dark enough, but small-scale and territory-bound—has expanded in unquantifiable ways after encountering the force-multiplying effect of the internet. The result is a mutant, Online Child Sexual Abuse, or OCSA, that seems to be infecting too many unlit corners in the country. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), whose four-year-old specialised Online Child Sexual Abuse and Exploitation (OCSAE) prevention/ investigation unit keeps an eagle-like vigil over this netherworld, defines the crime as sexual abuse or exploitation of minors using information and communications technology (ICT) as a means. This